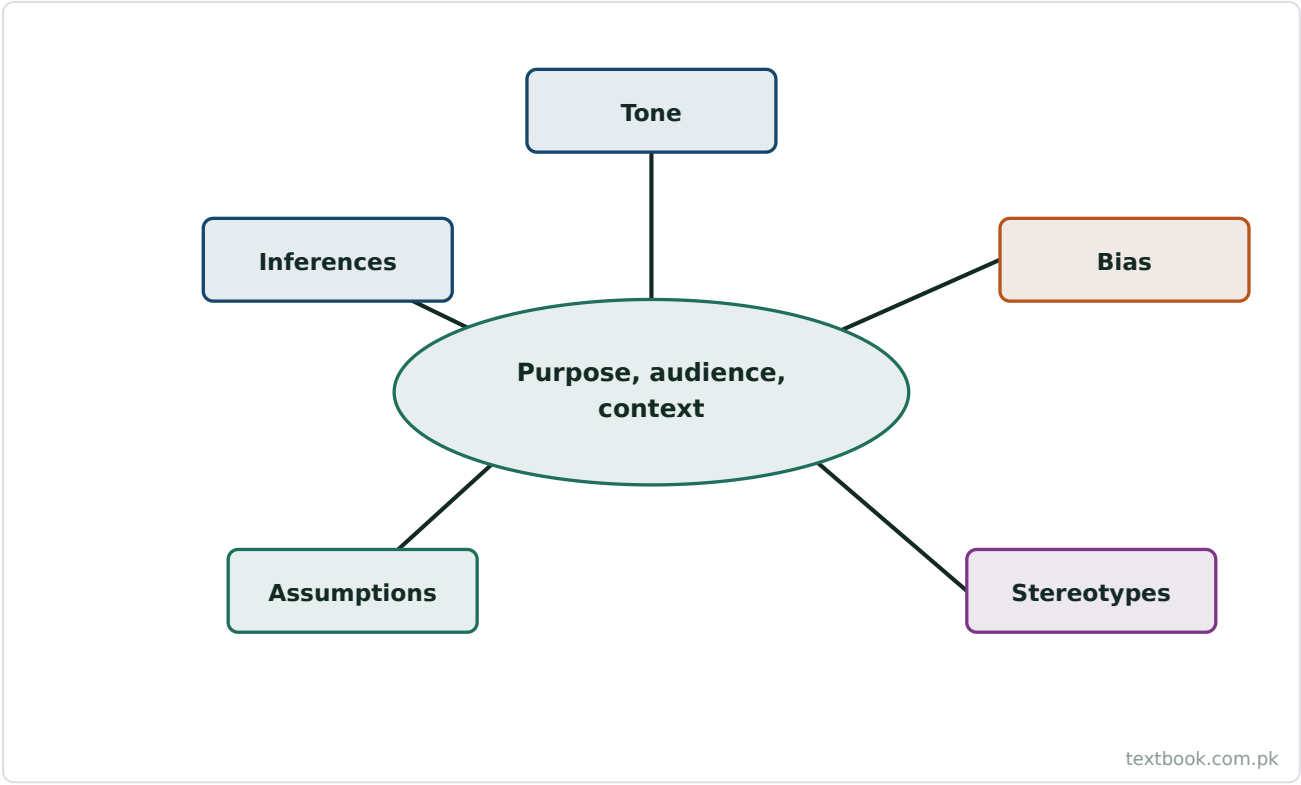
Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Topic 2.1 - Reading for purpose, audience and context

A real classroom situation



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Mr Sajid teaches Class 10 English in a government school in Lahore. He gives his pupils two texts about the same topic: a newspaper editorial and a textbook chapter. The editorial argues that mobile phones should be banned in schools; the textbook chapter explains how mobile networks work. Same topic, completely different texts. This topic is about why.

Explanation

A text does not exist in a vacuum. It is written by someone, for someone, for a reason. Understanding these three elements, purpose, audience and context, is the first step in reading critically.

Purpose, audience and context

Purpose is why a text was written. A text may aim to inform (a textbook), persuade (an editorial), entertain (a novel), instruct (a manual) or express (a poem). Most texts have more than one purpose, but one is usually dominant. Identifying the dominant purpose helps you understand what the writer is trying to achieve.

Audience is who the text is written for. A text for specialists uses technical language; a text for general readers does not. A text for children uses simpler sentence structures than a text for adults. Identifying the intended audience helps you understand the choices the writer has made.

Context is the situation in which the text was produced and is being read. A news article written during an election has a different context from one written during peacetime. A textbook written for Pakistani schools has a different context from one written for British schools. Context shapes what can be said and how it can be said.

The figure above maps the elements of purpose, audience and context and the features they produce.

Tone, bias, assumptions and inferences

Tone is the writer's attitude toward the subject or the audience. A text can be formal or informal, serious or humorous, respectful or sarcastic. Tone is created through word choice, sentence structure and the details the writer includes or leaves out.

Bias is a tendency to favour one perspective over others. All texts have some bias; the question is whether the bias is acknowledged or hidden. A biased text presents one side of an argument as if it were the only side.

Stereotype is a fixed, oversimplified belief about a group of people. Texts can reinforce stereotypes (women are emotional, rural people are ignorant) or challenge them. Identifying stereotypes is part of reading critically.

Assumption is something the writer takes for granted without stating it explicitly. A text that says "obviously, all parents want their children to succeed" assumes that this is universal. Identifying assumptions is part of understanding what a text does not say.

Inference is a conclusion the reader draws from evidence in the text. If a text says "the pupils entered the examination hall in silence and sat without speaking", you can infer that they were nervous, even though the text does not say so directly.

Common biases and stereotypes in the media

Stereotype	Example	More neutral alternative
Gender	women shown only as homemakers or caregivers	show people of all genders in varied roles
Rural / urban	rural people shown as backward or simple	present rural and urban life with equal respect
Religious	one faith shown as the norm, others as exotic	treat all faiths as equally familiar
Ethnic	a single ethnic group always cast as comic relief	share humour across groups, not at one group's cost
Age	older people always shown as frail or out of touch	show older and younger people contributing alike
Political	one party's view presented as plain fact	label opinions as opinions, name the standpoint

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The figure above maps common biases and stereotypes with examples from Pakistani media. Use it as a reference when you analyse texts.

Common misconception. "A text means what it says and nothing more." It does not. Every text contains assumptions, inferences and biases that the reader must identify. Reading critically means reading what is there and what is not there.

Activity: Analyse two texts on the same topic

Work in pairs. Take two texts on the same topic (a newspaper editorial and a textbook chapter, or a government pamphlet and a blog post). For each text, identify: the dominant purpose, the intended audience, the context, the tone, and at least one assumption or bias. Allow 25 minutes. Then compare with another pair and discuss any disagreements.

Check your understanding

1. Explain the difference between purpose and audience, and give one example of each. *(Remember)*
2. A text says, "Naturally, everyone agrees that education is important." Identify the assumption in this sentence and explain why it is an assumption. *(Analyze)*
3. Name the five features a reader can identify in a text (tone, bias, stereotypes, assumptions, inferences) and give one example of each. *(Remember)*
4. A news article describes a protest as "a small group of troublemakers". Identify the bias in this description and explain what a more neutral description might be. *(Analyze)*
5. Explain the difference between what a text says explicitly and what the reader infers, and give one example of each. *(Understand)*

Summary

Purpose, audience and context shape every text. Tone, bias, stereotypes, assumptions and inferences are the features a critical reader identifies. Reading critically means reading what is there and what is not there, and understanding the choices the writer has made.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can explain the difference between purpose, audience and context.
- [ ] I can identify tone, bias, stereotypes, assumptions and inferences in a text.
- [ ] I can explain the difference between explicit meaning and inference.
- [ ] I can analyse a described text for purpose, audience and context.
- [ ] I can identify what a text assumes but does not state.

Try this at your practicum school

Collect two English texts used in the class you are observing (a textbook passage and a worksheet, or a textbook passage and a newspaper article). For each, identify purpose, audience, context, tone and at least one assumption or bias. Write half a page on how the two texts differ and what that tells you about the reading demands placed on the pupils.

Summative task

Write 350 to 400 words on the following.

> Read the following text: "The government has announced a new initiative to improve girls' education in rural areas. Under the programme, schools will receive additional funding and female teachers will be given priority in recruitment. Officials say the initiative will help bridge the gender gap in literacy." Using this topic's account of purpose, audience, context, tone, bias, assumptions and inferences, analyse the text. Identify at least three features and explain what each reveals about the writer's choices.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Identification of purpose, audience and context (Understand)	States all three with evidence from the text

Criterion	What a strong response does
Identification of tone, bias, assumptions or inferences (Analyze)	Identifies at least three features with evidence
Analysis of what the features reveal (Analyze)	**Explains what each feature reveals about the writer's choices, not just names the feature**
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Johns, J., & Lenski, S. *Improving Reading: Strategies, Resources, and Common Core Connections.* (guide recommended)
- Kintsch, W. *Comprehension: A Paradigm for Cognition.* (guide recommended)
- James, M., & Merickel, A. P. *Reading Literature and Writing Argument.* (guide recommended)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback